

Architecting for the Future

Andrew Sales, Chief Methodologist



Exponential

Rapid technological growth



Generative

AI's creative capabilities



EDGE

Disruptive

Industry-wide transformations



Emergent

Unpredictable system behaviors



Architecting for the Future



Build an
Adaptive
Operating Model



Unlock
Real Returns
with AI



Achieve
AI-Empowered
Agility

Architecting for the Future



**Build an
Adaptive
Operating Model**



Unlock
Real Returns
with AI



Achieve
AI-Empowered
Agility

**When that ecosystem is healthy—
evidenced by the organization's ability
to constantly sense shifts, prune
unproductive activities, and nurture
new growth avenues—transformations
are rarely needed, and when they do
occur, they are more productive.**

—Harvard Business Review, *Get Off the Transformation Treadmill*

Lean Portfolio Management

Enabling Strategy Agility

Large Solution Integration and Delivery

Building Large-Scale Systems

Product Development Flow

Developing Innovative Customer-Centric Products

Team and Technical Agility

Accelerating Value Delivery

Leadership and Culture

Establishing a New Way of Working

NEW Leadership & Culture Discipline



Lean-Agile Organization

Become a Lean-Agile Leader



Lean-Agile
Mindset



Core
Values



SAFe
Principles

Empower a Continuous Learning Culture



Continuous Learning
and Innovation



Communities
of Practice



Measure
and Grow



Executives
and Leaders



Local
Champions



LACE



SPCs and
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Guiding Coalition

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Train everyone.

Launch trains.

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Customize SAFe to Your Context

PEOPLE

Roles



Groups



WORK

Work items



Workflows



Work artifacts



ACTIVITIES

Events



Practices



**Purpose
of event**

Intent

Outcome

Inputs and Outputs

**Facilitation guides
are available**

[Home](#) » [Iteration Planning](#) Outcome Additions

Iteration Planning

“ *Stay committed to your decisions but stay flexible in your approach.* ”

—Tony Robbins

Summary

Iteration Planning is an Agile Team event where the team members commit to the work they will deliver in the upcoming timebox, known as an iteration. The team collaboratively defines a set of Iteration Goals and selects the stories from the team backlog that they believe they can complete to meet those goals. This planning is informed by the team's capacity and historical

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What is Iteration Planning?

Iteration planning is the first event of the iteration. During planning, the team defines, organizes, and commits to the work for the next iteration. The iteration planning meeting is timeboxed to approximately 90 minutes for a two-week iteration. The team's backlog has been partially identified and planned during PI Planning. In addition, the teams have feedback—not only from their prior iterations but also from the System Demo, stakeholders, and others. This context informs the iteration planning event, shaping the plan for the upcoming iteration.

What is the purpose of Iteration Planning?

The Agile Team members use the Iteration Planning event to commit to a set of iteration goals for the upcoming timebox. They plan a set of stories they feel they can complete to achieve these goals.

The business, often represented by the Product Owner or key stakeholders, is involved to validate that the work the team intends to do will move the team and the business in the intended direction.

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How does Iteration Planning connect with the SAFe Principles?

SAFe Principle #1: Take an economic view: In every iteration, the Agile Team should decide on the most appropriate work to maximize value for the business, rather than blindly following a predefined sequence. The team is problem-solving, and problem-solving often requires adapting plans as the true nature of the problem becomes clear through working on it.

SAFe Principle #8: Unlock the intrinsic motivation of knowledge workers: The people doing the work are the best equipped to determine how to do it and how much they can complete. The Agile Team members determine how to do the work they face and share with the business and other Agile Teams how much work they can do within the fixed iteration timebox

Read more about SAFe Principle #1 and SAFe Principle #8:

SAFe Principle #1

SAFe Principle #8

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What is the outcome of Iteration Planning?

The primary outcome is the mutual commitment between the Agile Team and the business to the iteration goals. The team commits to achieving the goals, and the business commits to keeping the goals stable for the duration of the timebox. This event also results in a shared understanding of all necessary internal and external collaborations.

What are the inputs and outputs?

Inputs to iteration planning include:

- **Iteration goals** are a high-level summary of the business and technical goals that an Agile Team agrees to accomplish in an iteration. These are typically derived from the PI Objectives created during PI Planning, but may also include local insights from the team. While the Product Owner is accountable for ensuring that the iteration goals exist, determining them is typically a collaborative effort.
- **Stories** are drawn from the team backlog to satisfy the iteration goal. The Product Owner is accountable for ensuring a prioritized backlog of stories. Creating and prioritizing the stories is a collaborative effort among stakeholders and the Agile Team. Stories will include those from the team's PI plan, identified during PI Planning and tentatively assigned to iterations;

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- **Capacity** is an understanding of how much plannable work the Agile Team can undertake in the Iteration being planned. The team estimates their upcoming capacity using a known historical velocity, based on the average number of story points an Agile Team has

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AI-Empowered Iteration

- **AI-Generated Stories and Intent Validation:** Use AI agents to generate initial stories and acceptance criteria, shifting the team's focus to critically validating and refining the output for alignment.
- **Predictive and Proactive Capacity Planning:** Employ AI to analyze complex factors beyond historical velocity, like non-working days and potential risks, for a more accurate capacity commitment.
- **AI-Powered Backlog Prioritization:** Implement AI tools to analyze historical data and business goals to suggest an optimal prioritization, allowing the team to focus planning time on implementation rather than manual ordering.
- **AI-Drafted Iteration Goals:** Leverage an AI agent to draft initial, high-fidelity iteration goals that link the prioritized stories to the PI objectives.

Access SAFe Studio Practical Tools



[Iteration Planning Facilitator Guide](#)

NEW Leadership & Culture Discipline



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Solving Your Business Problems...

Organizing Portfolios

Business Problem: We struggle to execute our desired strategy across the existing portfolio structures.

Lean-Agile Procurement

Business Problem: Our partner selection processes are slow, siloed, and misaligned with evolving business needs.

Validating Investment Opportunities

Business Problem: We often make investment decisions that lead to unrealized value and wasted effort.

Enabling Agility with Enterprise Architecture

Business Problem: Our inconsistent technology and design choices create duplicated technical efforts, poor user experiences, and increased costs.

Managing a Balanced Portfolio

Business Problem: We struggle to balance immediate needs with strategic initiatives, leading to inefficient delivery of the most critical portfolio work.

Transitioning to Value Stream Funding

Business Problem: Our traditional approach to funding prevents us from being responsive to opportunities.

...with SAFe Competencies

Organizing Portfolios Competency

Why

Learning

Applying

Mastering

Example

Next Steps

Business Problem

Our organization struggles to execute our desired strategy across the existing portfolio structure, resulting in lost revenue, inability to meet our strategic goals, and decreased market share.

Business Outcomes

- Organizing portfolios around value increases the flow of strategic work.
- Clarifying the scope and responsibility of each portfolio promotes decentralized decision-making and increases responsiveness to emerging opportunities.
- Portfolio Leaders proactively find ways for cross-portfolio collaboration in support of the organization's strategic goals.
- Wasteful work and duplication of efforts across portfolios are minimized.

Why is it important to be competent in Organizing Portfolios?

In today's volatile market, organizing around value to match the company's strategy and vision is essential for success. This alignment ensures everyone is working towards the same goals, preventing wasted resources and missed opportunities. By coordinating efforts, organizations can adapt quickly to market shifts, seize new opportunities, and outperform competitors. It also unlocks the ability to have clear visibility into progress and performance through understanding where the value is flowing and which teams are associated with what major elements of the strategy.

SAFe defines a portfolio as a set of value streams that deliver products and solutions to customers within a common funding and governance model. Each portfolio has a purpose, a context, and a structure. The aim of the portfolio is twofold: to support existing business and drive new strategies across the organization. Organizing your portfolios effectively plays a crucial role in ensuring these aims can be achieved and enables a continuous flow of value to your customers.

A well-organized set of portfolios also enables better strategic alignment, which supports improved execution and empowers your teams and Agile Release Trains (ARTs) to make informed choices. This enables decentralized decision-making in line with SAFe Principle #9 and helps prioritize work that delivers the most value. Additionally, effective portfolio structures lead to optimized resource utilization, enhancing your investment decisions.

Which roles would benefit from mastering this competency?

The Organizing Portfolios Competency enables leaders responsible for strategic value delivery and alignment. The specific roles that generally require mastering this competency are Portfolio Leadership, the Value Management Office (VMO), Enterprise Architects, the Lean-Agile Center of Excellence (LACE), and SPCs supporting the implementation of Lean Portfolio Management.

Applying the Organizing Portfolios Competency

The Organizing Portfolios for Strategic Agility Workshop helps you apply the Organizing SAFe Portfolios Competency. In this workshop, you'll build a portfolio structure that connects strategy to execution, creating a foundation for business agility, faster time to market, and sustainable growth. The workshop includes two assets for interactive learning and decision-making.

- The Overview Session** is designed for portfolio coaches, change agents, and members of the Lean-Agile Center of Excellence (LACE). Through real-world scenarios, you'll explore how to structure portfolios for strategic alignment. Discover proven portfolio structures and gain clarity on how to guide your organization through complex change.
- The Workshop Session** is built for senior portfolio leaders and key stakeholders. In this working session, you'll identify the right portfolio structures for your organization and align on a clear action plan. You'll leave with defined portfolio structures, completed portfolio canvases, and a practical change strategy to drive execution at scale.

Organizing Portfolios for Strategic Agility Workshop

The workshop includes a comprehensive kit with presentation decks, facilitator enablement videos, a guide, and other resources to maximize your outcomes and drive lasting improvements.

[Download the workshop as an ASPC or SPC-T](#)

Portfolio Canvas

A portfolio canvas for each portfolio is helpful because it allows for a concise, visual representation of the portfolio's strategy, value streams, and initiatives. This clarity aids in aligning the organization's efforts, ensuring everyone understands how their work contributes to strategic objectives. It also facilitates improved decision-making about the boundaries of each portfolio.

[Download the Portfolio Canvas](#)

[total time 15 mins](#)

Mastering the Organizing Portfolios Competency

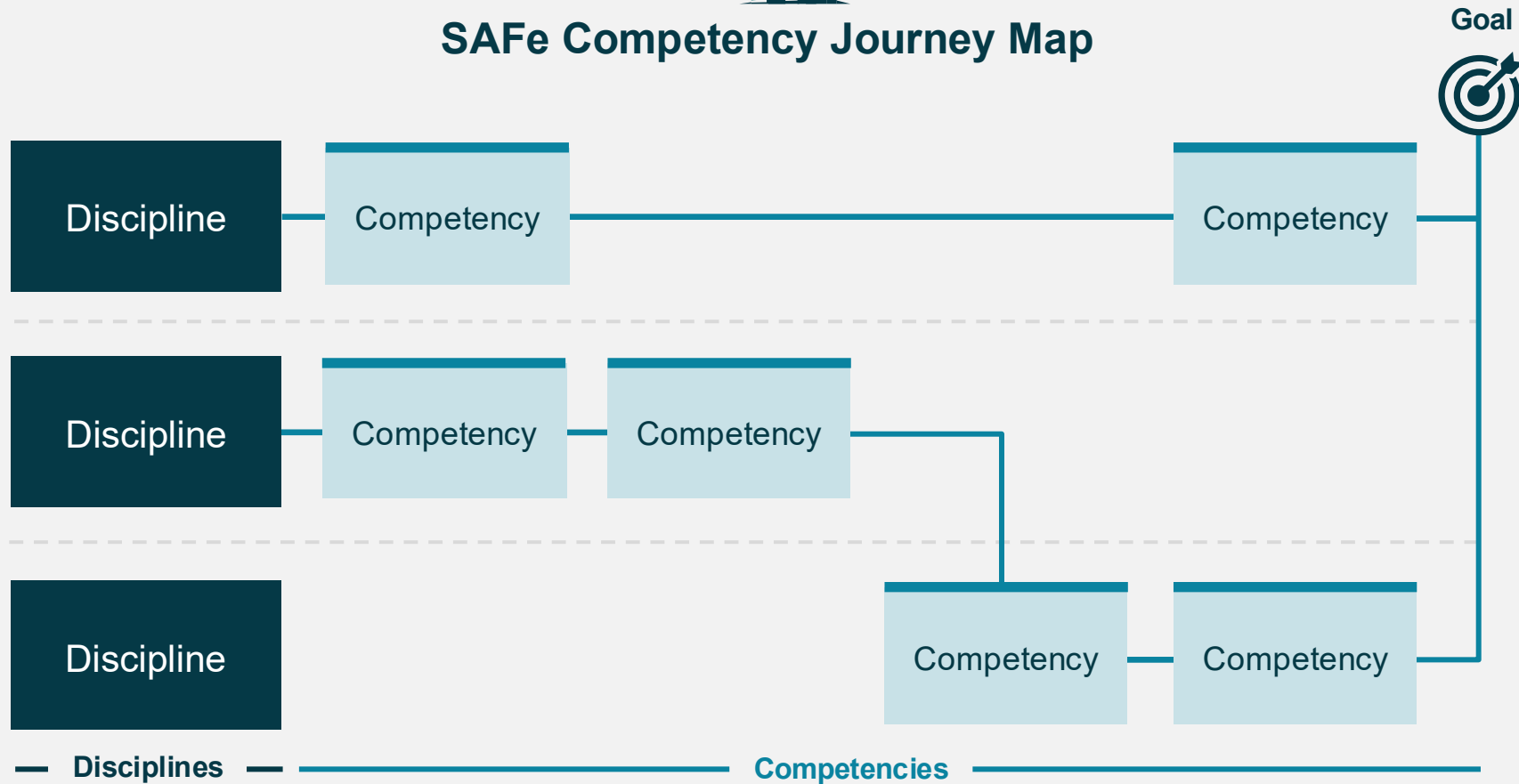
Competence in organizing portfolios, formulating strategies, coordinating value streams, and Agile portfolio operations work together to effectively achieve the potential of strategy agility.

When an organization effectively masters the ability to organize and reorganize its portfolios, clear indicators emerge. Organizations dynamically adapt to evolving business strategies, evidenced by the seamless formation of new portfolios or adjustments to the boundaries of existing portfolios to enhance strategic flow. Portfolio leaders anticipate and proactively address potential roadblocks arising from organizational structures, ensuring smooth execution. Furthermore, leadership teams demonstrate an acute awareness of the inherent strengths and weaknesses of chosen organizational constructs, mitigating challenges while empowering decentralized decision-making where appropriate.

Effective mastery also manifests in the organization's ability to clearly articulate and execute a cross-portfolio strategy. Portfolio leaders gain a deep understanding of their contribution to the organizational strategy, as well as the alignment with other portfolios. Waste and duplication are minimized



SAFe Competency Journey Map



NEW Leadership & Culture Discipline



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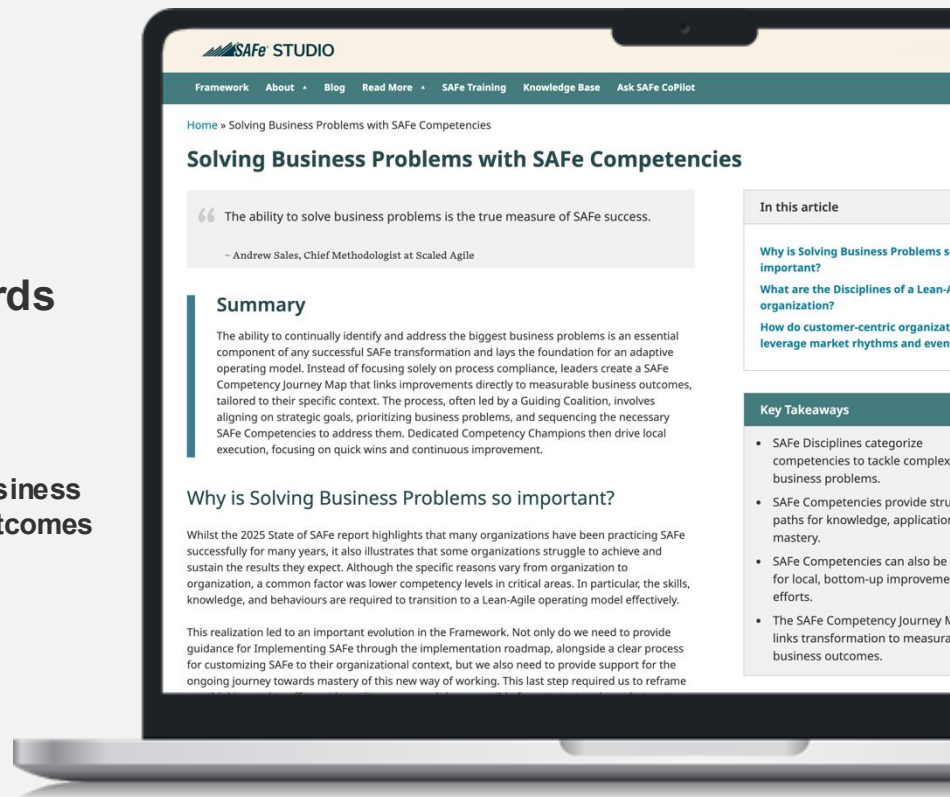
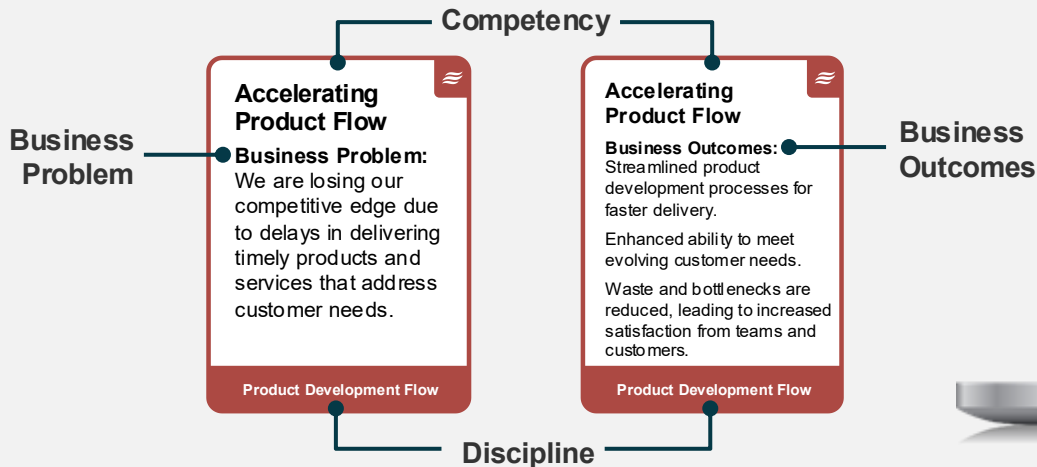


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NEW Solving Business Problems Article

- ◆ Guidance for identifying your biggest business problems
- ◆ An adaptable process for creating **SAFe Competency Journey Maps**
- ◆ Downloadable **SAFe Competency Cards**

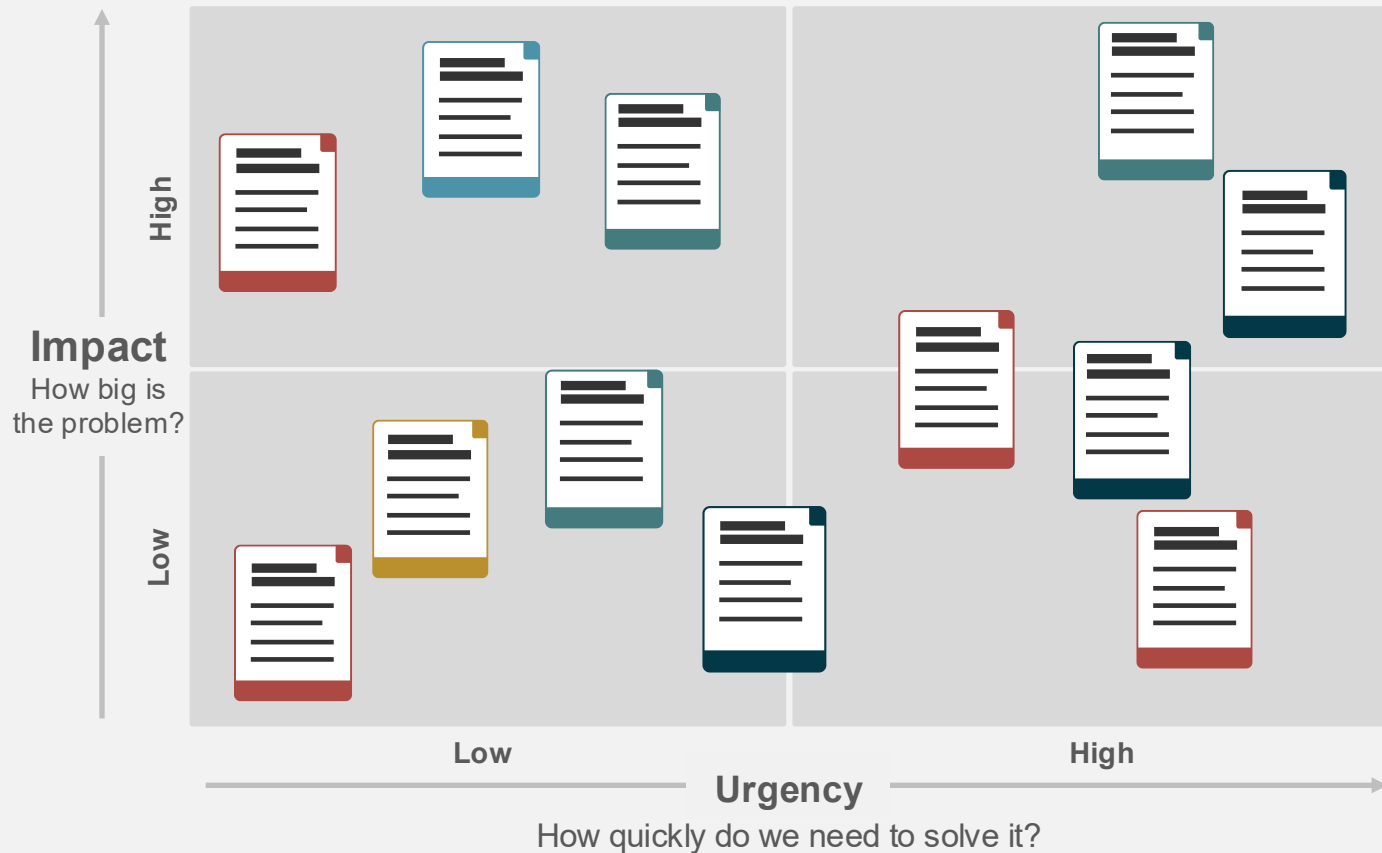




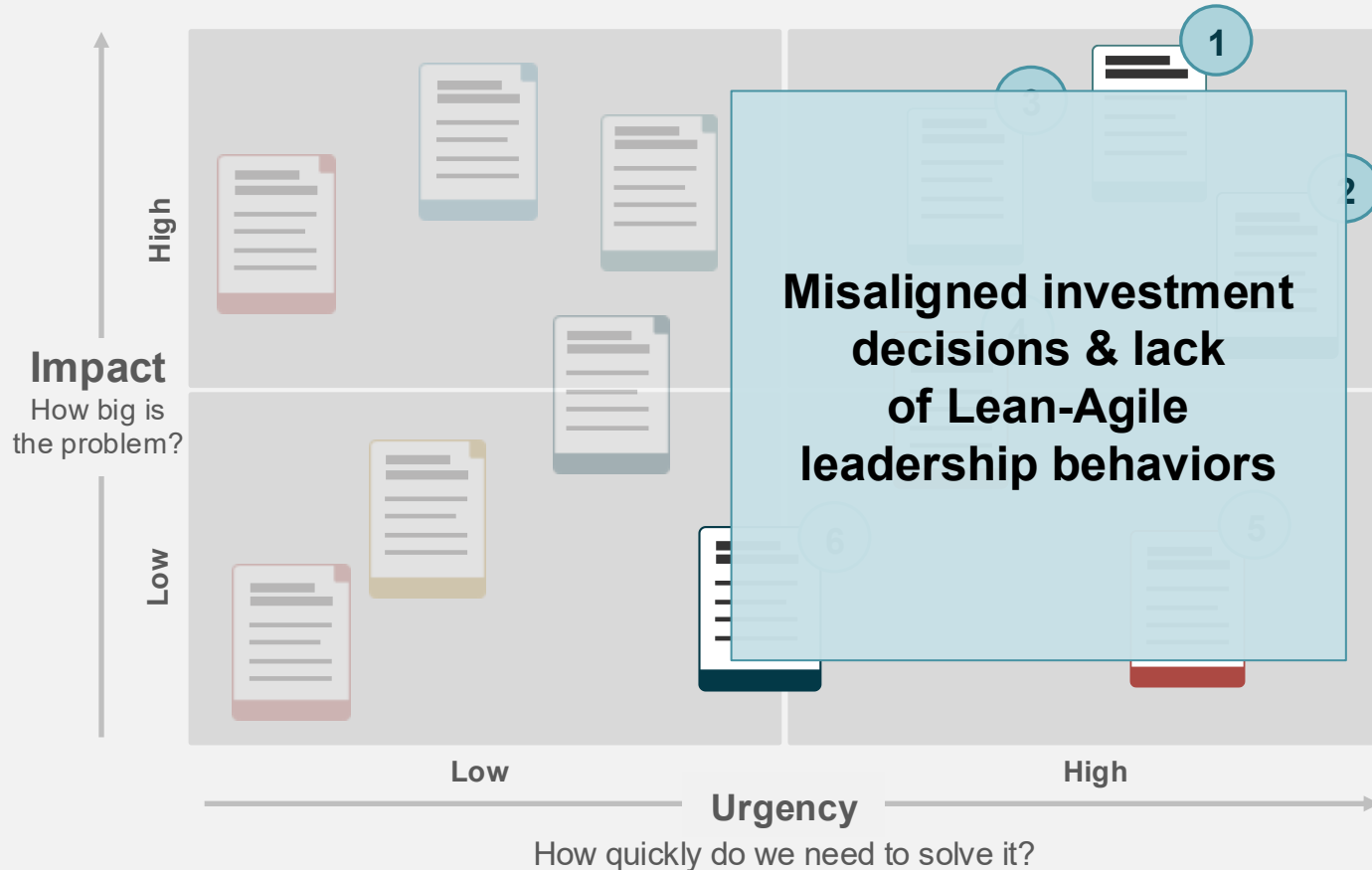
Become a

Align on the Goal
Customer-Centric Organization

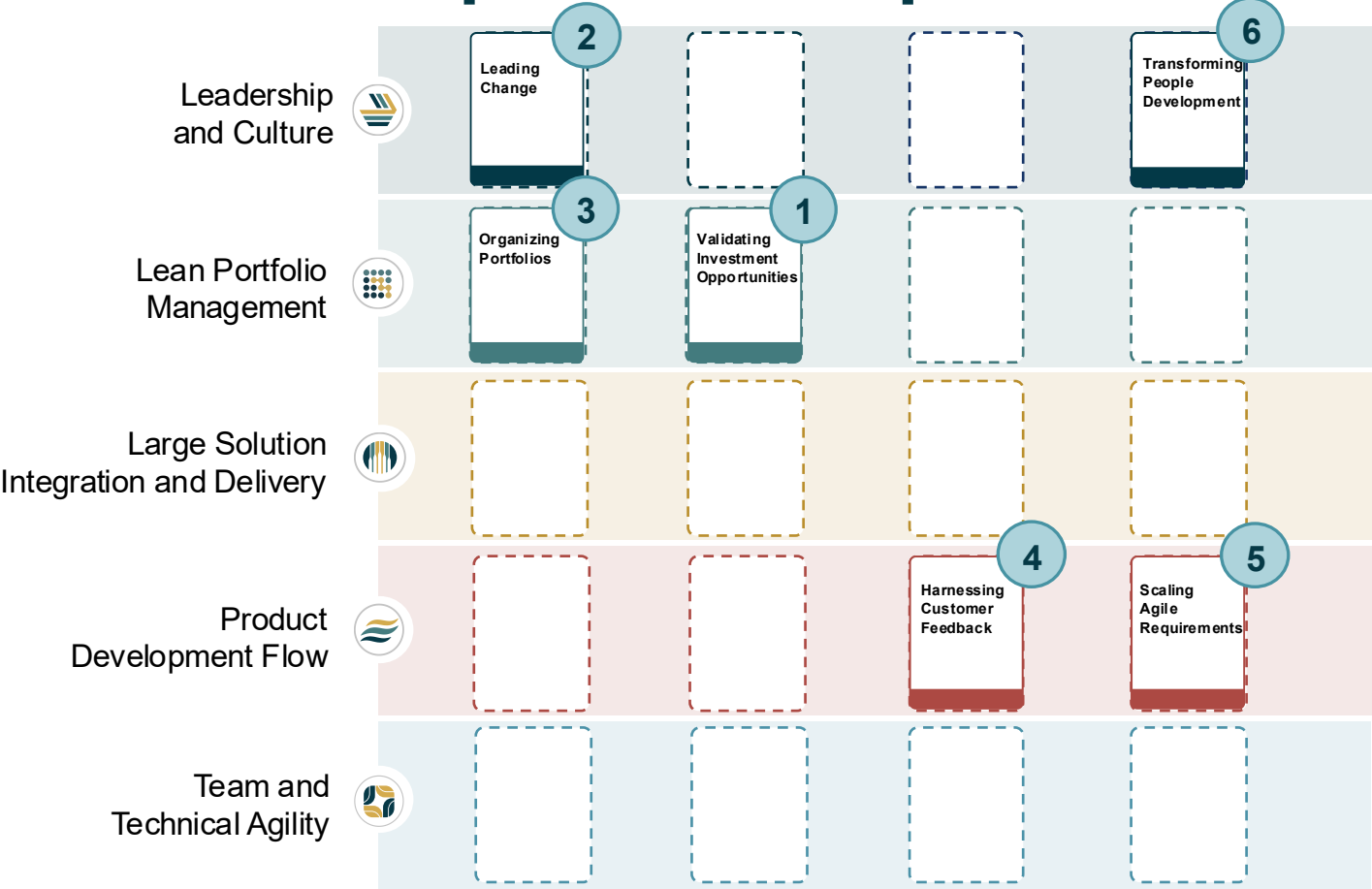
Prioritize Business Problems



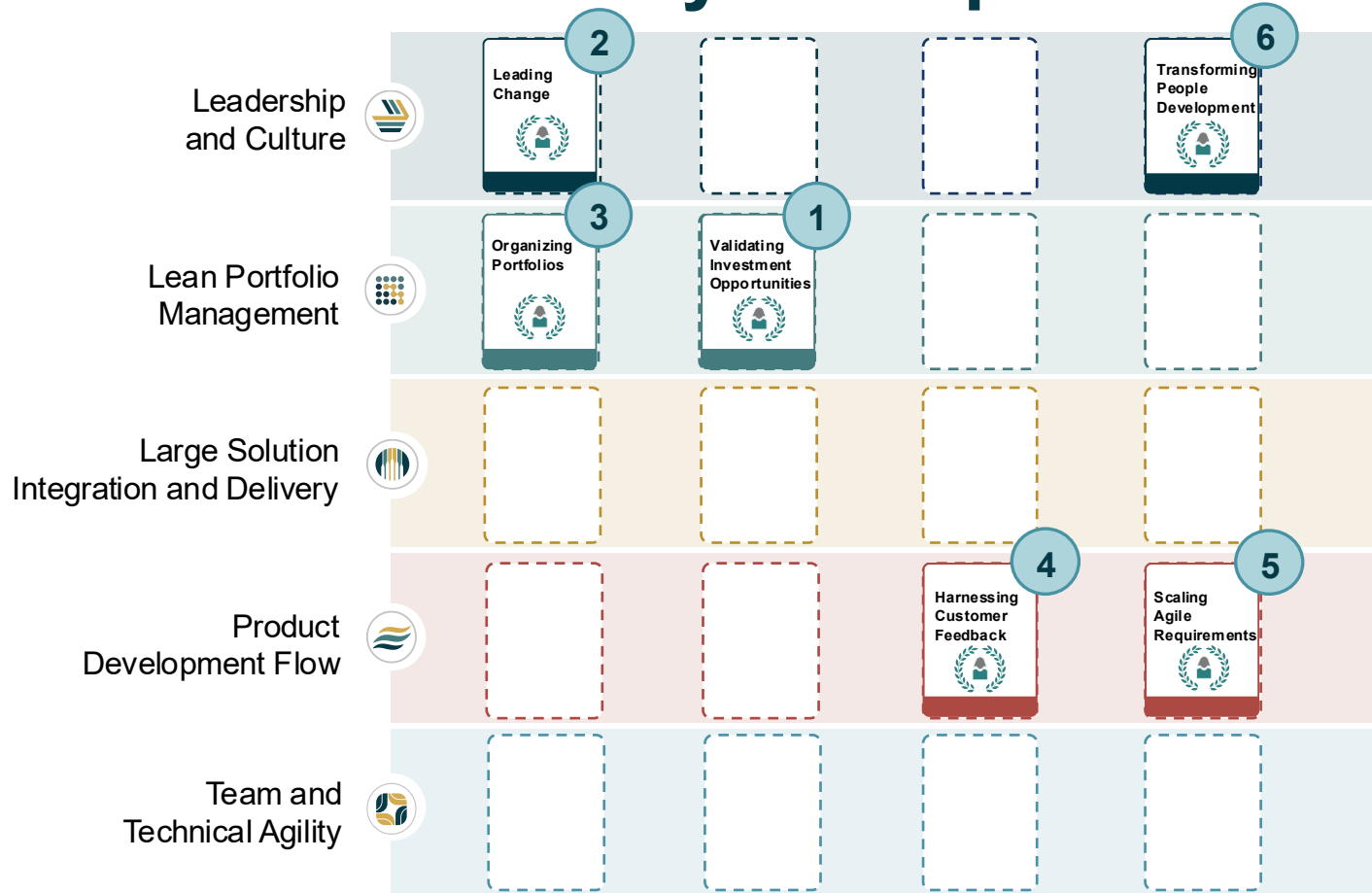
Prioritize Business Problems



Sequence Competencies



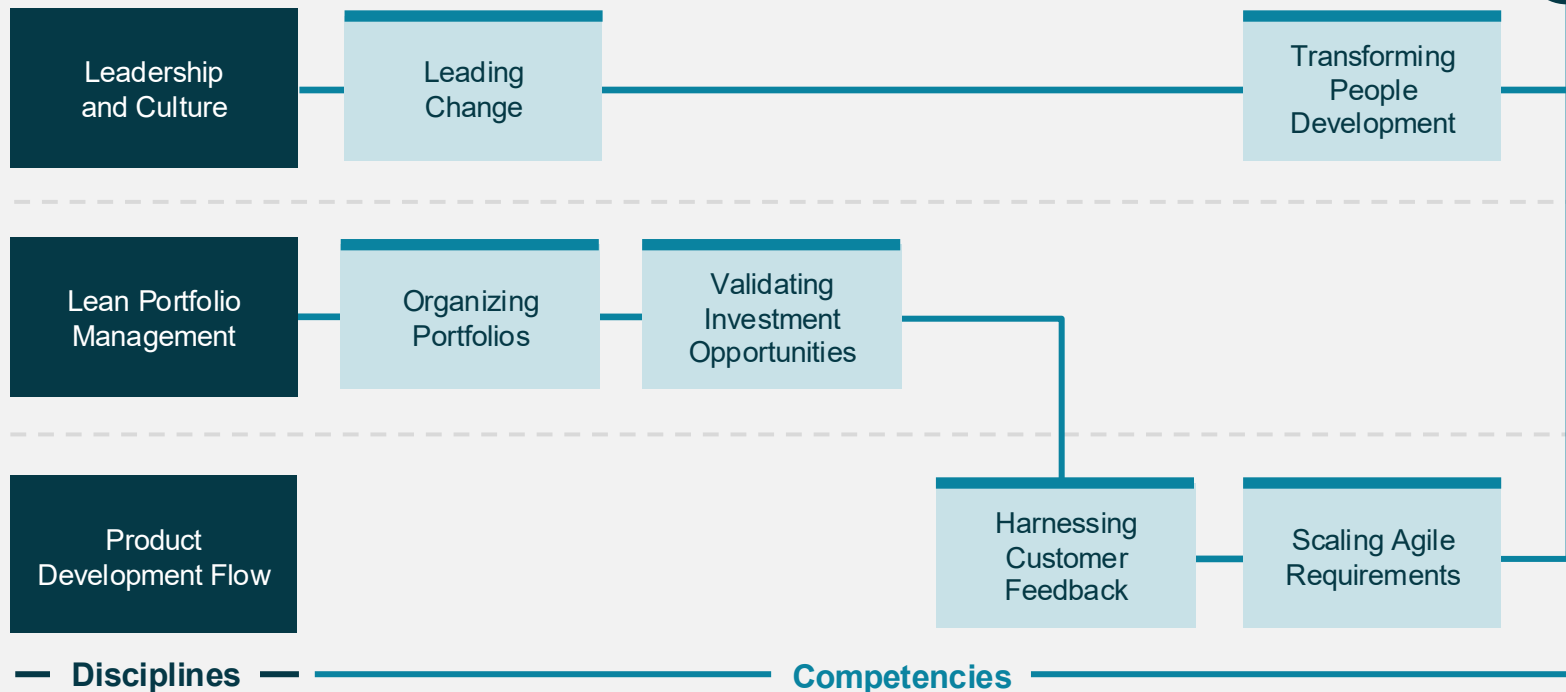
Identify Champions



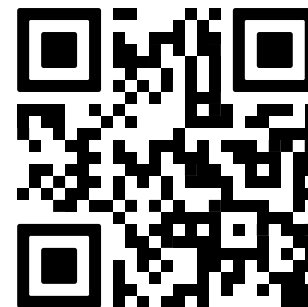
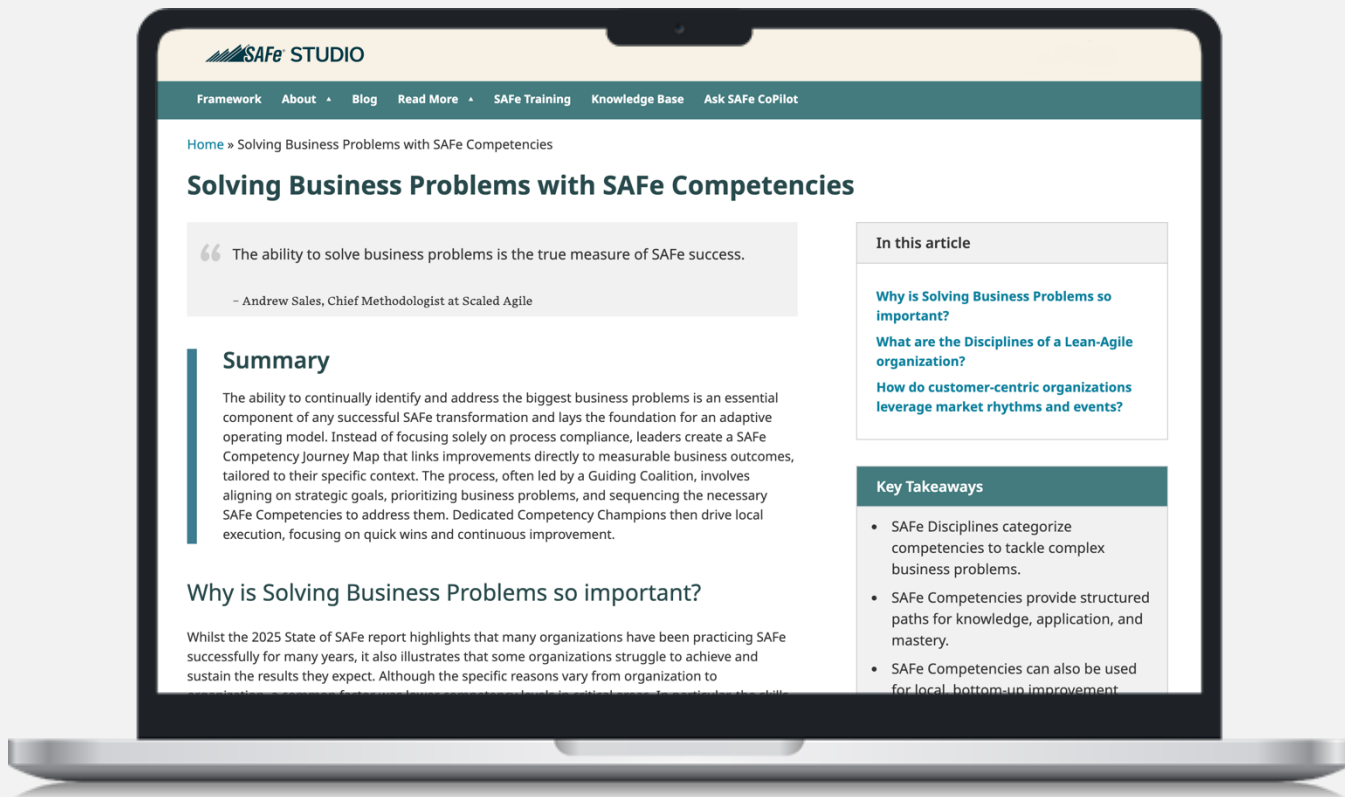


SAFe Competency Journey Map

Become a
Customer-Centric
Organization



NEW Solving Business Problems Article



Scan to read the article

Architecting for the Future



Build an Adaptive
Operating Model



**Unlock
Real Returns
with AI**



Achieve
AI-Empowered
Agility



Converted customer support into a \$1.4B profit center
through AI-driven upskilling

Streamlined 47% of rote tasks
and transformed 8,500 agents
into design advisors

**Generated \$1.4 billion
in new revenue**

Only 9% of companies
are achieving AI value
at scale.

–Return on AI Institute, *Economic Maturity of Artificial Intelligence 2026*



The Possibilities of AI Seem Endless

A word cloud centered around the theme of AI possibilities. The words are arranged in a circular pattern, with 'Agentic Workflows' being the largest and most central. Other prominent words include 'Trend Forecasting', 'Data Provenance', 'Workflow Synthesis', and 'Smart Summarization'. Smaller words like 'Instant Drafting', 'Rapid Prototyping', 'Contextual Awareness', 'Decision Support', 'Task Orchestration', 'Vibe Coding', 'Hyper-Personalization', and 'Predictive Insights' are also included. The words are decorated with small, light blue starburst icons.

Trend Forecasting

Instant Drafting Rapid Prototyping

Contextual Awareness

Decision Support Task Orchestration Vibe Coding

Agentic Workflows

Hyper-Personalization Workflow Synthesis

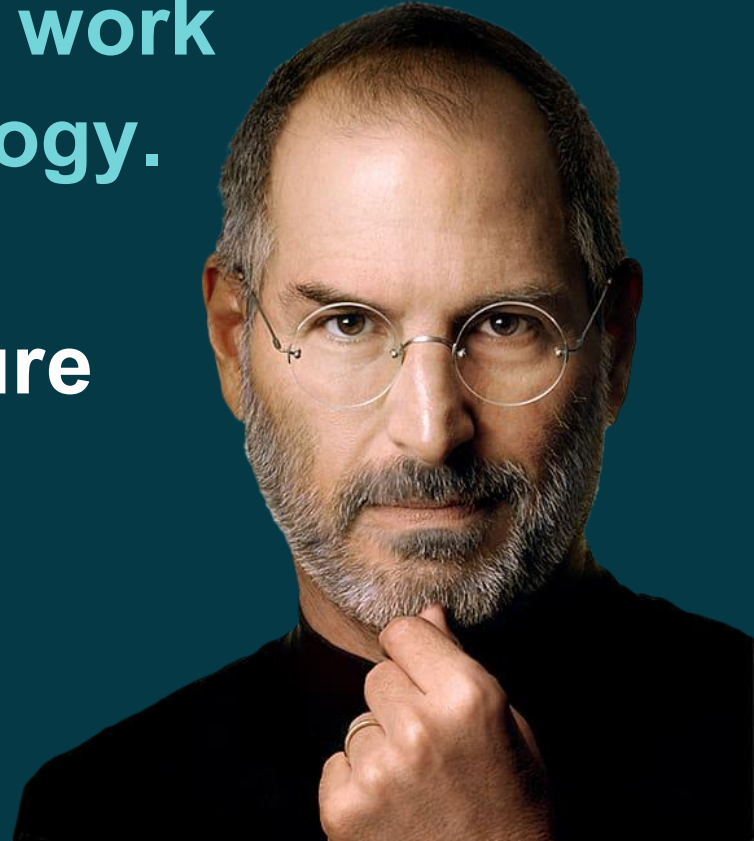
Data Provenance

Predictive Insights

Smart Summarization

“You’ve got to start with the customer experience and work backwards to the technology. You can’t start with the technology and try to figure out where you’re going to try and sell it.”

—Steve Jobs, Apple



How Organizations Create Value





5 Proven AI Value Patterns



5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support

**Building
Product and
Services**

Scaling
Growth

**Driving
Operational
Efficiencies**

Improving
Quality and
Mitigating Risk

AI that synthesizes information, surfaces insights, and augments human judgment—answering questions, summarizing data, recommending actions



5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support
2. **Customer Interaction**

Building
Product and
Services

**Scaling
Growth**

**Driving
Operational
Efficiencies**

Improving
Quality and
Mitigating Risk

AI that engages directly with customers—chatbots, personalized recommendations, voice assistants, service automation



5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support
2. Customer Interaction
3. **Workforce Automation**

Building
Product and
Services

Scaling
Growth

Driving
Operational
Efficiencies

Improving
Quality and
Mitigating Risk

AI that executes repetitive tasks, routes work, processes documents, and handles high-volume operations without human intervention



5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support
2. Customer Interaction
3. Workforce Automation
4. **Risk and Control**

Building
Product and
Services

Scaling
Growth

Driving
Operational
Efficiencies

Improving
Quality and
Mitigating Risk

AI that detects anomalies, monitors compliance, identifies fraud, and enforces governance—the “watchdog” pattern



5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support
2. Customer Interaction
3. Workforce Automation
4. Risk and Control
5. **Expert Productivity**

**Building
Product and
Services**

Scaling
Growth

**Driving
Operational
Efficiencies**

Improving
Quality and
Mitigating Risk

AI that amplifies the output of skilled workers—code generation for developers, research acceleration for analysts, drafting for legal/finance



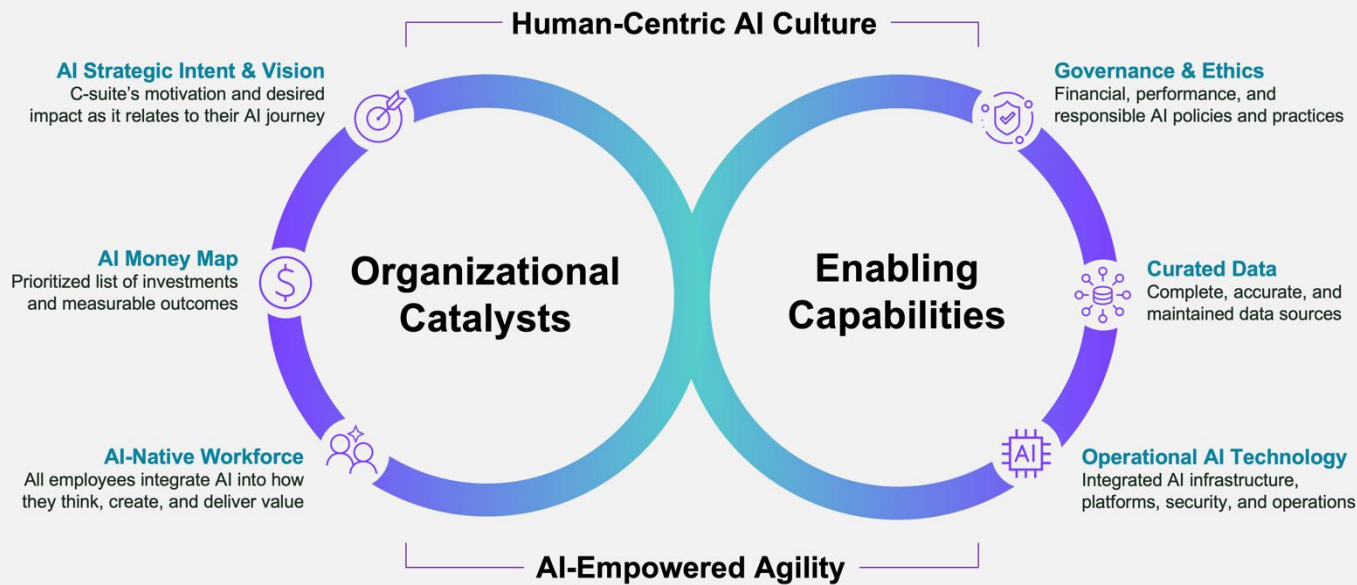
5 Proven AI Value Patterns

1. Knowledge and Decision Support
2. Customer Interaction
3. Workforce Automation
4. Risk and Control
5. Expert Productivity

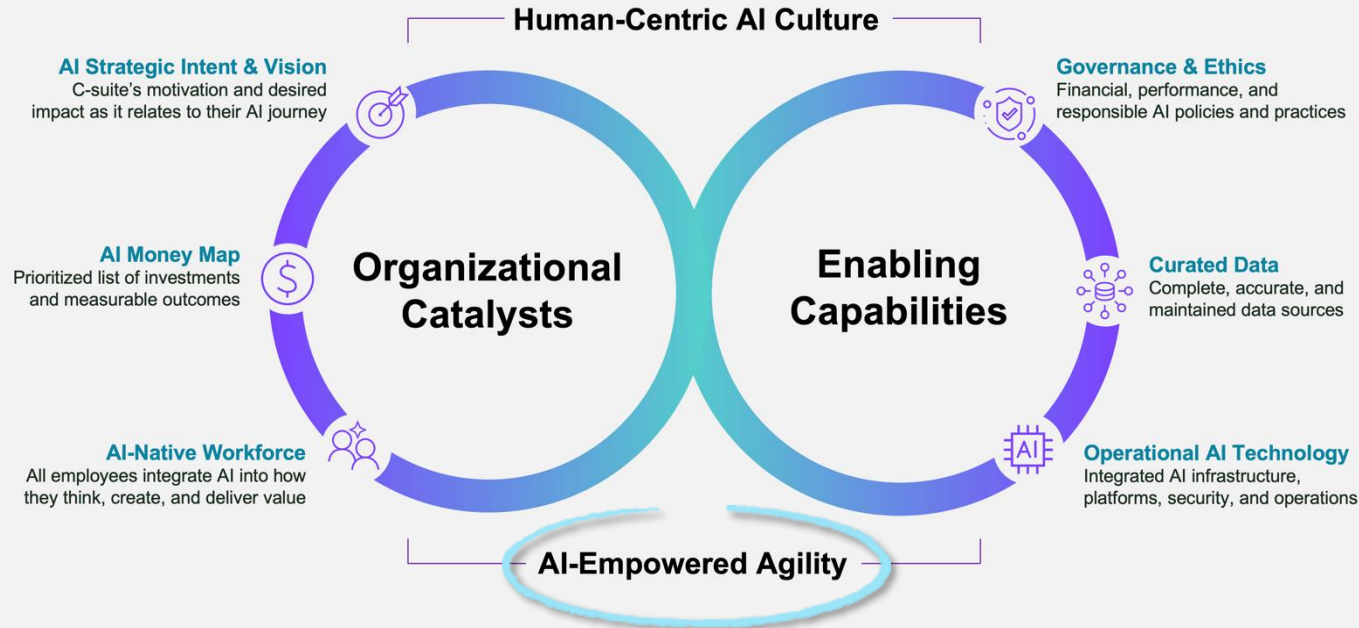




NEW Leading an AI-Native Organization



NEW Leading an AI-Native Organization



Architecting for the Future



Build an Adaptive
Operating Model



Unlock
Real Returns
with AI



**Achieve
AI-Empowered
Agility**



AI-Empowered Agility

The capability to rapidly and responsibly develop and deploy AI-driven solutions

Whilst also **leveraging AI to continuously enhance the speed, quality, and adaptability of Lean-Agile methods.**



AI-Empowered Agility

Focus on Outcomes

Iterative Learning Cycles

Development at Scale

Cross-Functional Teams



AI-Empowered Agility

Focus on Outcomes



Focus on Outcomes & **Intent**

Iterative Learning Cycles

Development at Scale

Cross-Functional Teams



Include Intent in Requirements

FEATURE PROMPT:

Role: You are acting as a Senior Systems Architect and Lead Developer on our Vehicle Routing Agile Team. The feature you are developing with us is called **High Reliability Traffic Data**.

Benefit Hypothesis: By implementing a resilient, low-latency connection between the in-vehicle app and backend road-insight services, we will improve service quality through faster routing updates and more reliable data delivery, even in areas of intermittent connectivity.

Intent: Ensure the driver is offered the most expedient route, even when driving through low-signal areas such as tunnels or low-signal areas.



Include Intent in Requirements

The Challenge: We need a data synchronization strategy that balances real-time road insights with the reality of fluctuating cellular connectivity.

Parameters for our Pairing Session:

1. **Data Freshness vs. Reliability:** Propose a logic flow that prioritizes local cached data for immediate rendering while fetching background delta-updates.
2. **Failure Strategy:** Instead of just "retrying," design an "intelligent degradation" model. If the backend is slow, how does the app behave to maintain the Benefit Hypothesis?
3. **Protocol Selection:** Evaluate whether WebSockets or gRPC-web is better for this specific "In-Vehicle to Cloud" context, accounting for battery and data overhead.

Your Task: Draft a **high-level technical design** and a sequence diagram that satisfies the "Quality of Service" hypothesis. Don't just give me code; explain how your choices protect the user experience during a network drop.



AI-Empowered Agility

Focus on Outcomes >>> Focus on Outcomes & **Intent**

Iterative Learning Cycles >>> Iterative Learning & **Rapid Experimentation Cycles**

Development at Scale

Cross-Functional Teams

Accelerate Feedback Loops

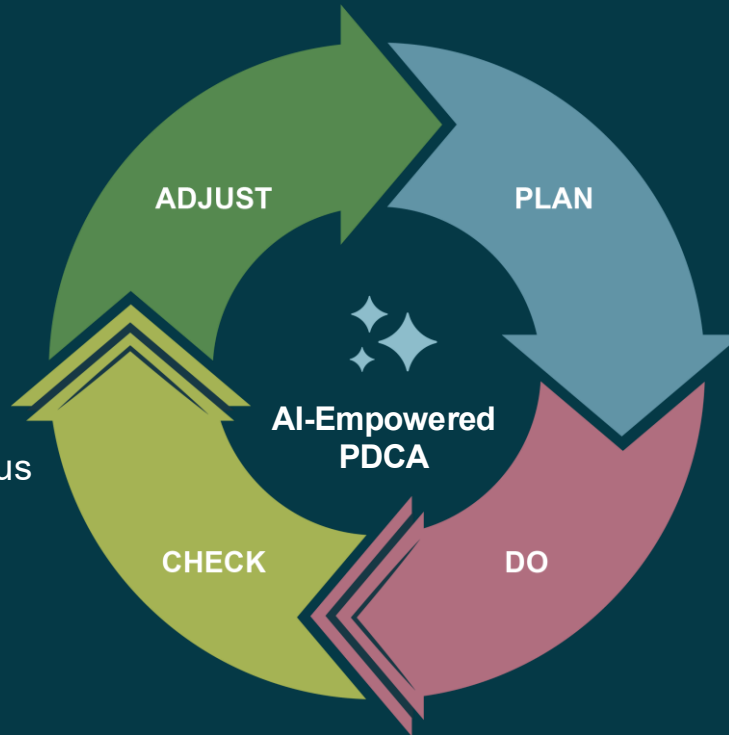


AI generates insights

HUMANS devote more time to decision-making

AI enables near-instantaneous quality checks

HUMANS focus on review and validation



AI generates multiple options and ideas for potential new work

HUMANS devote more time to strategy and customers

AI drastically accelerates this phase

HUMANS provide intent and context



AI-Empowered Agility

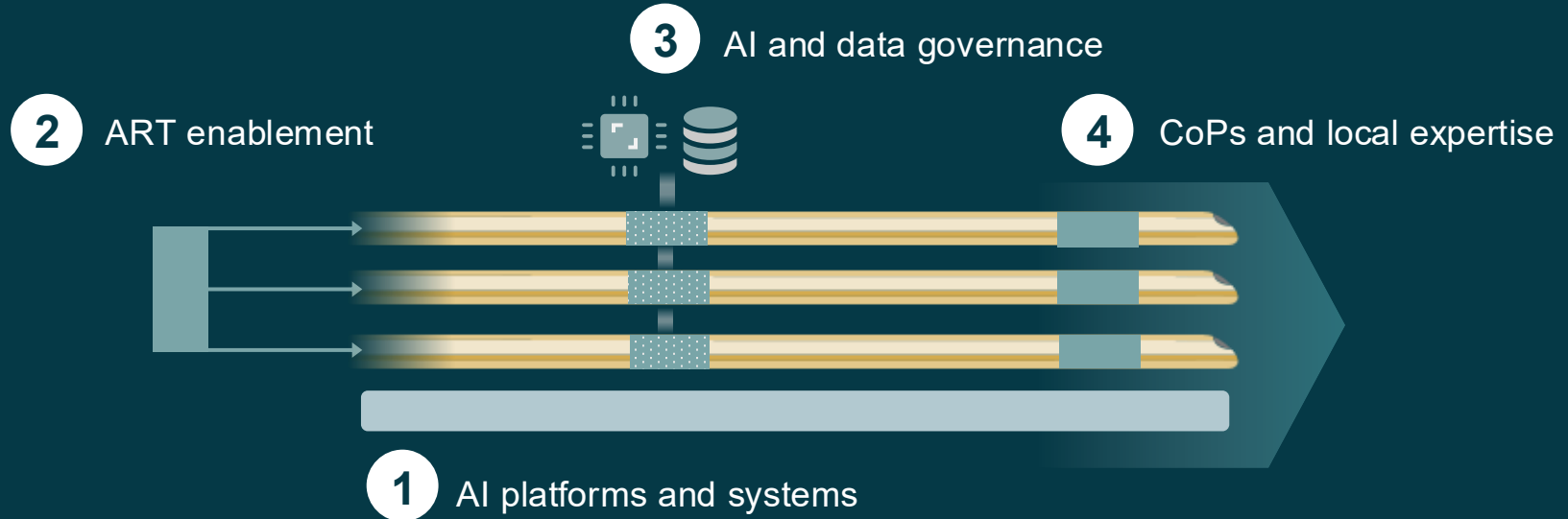
Focus on Outcomes >>> Focus on Outcomes & **Intent**

Iterative Learning Cycles >>> Iterative Learning & **Rapid Experimentation Cycles**

Development at Scale >>> Development & **Innovation at Scale**

Cross-Functional Teams

Build and Govern Operational AI Technologies





AI-Empowered Agility

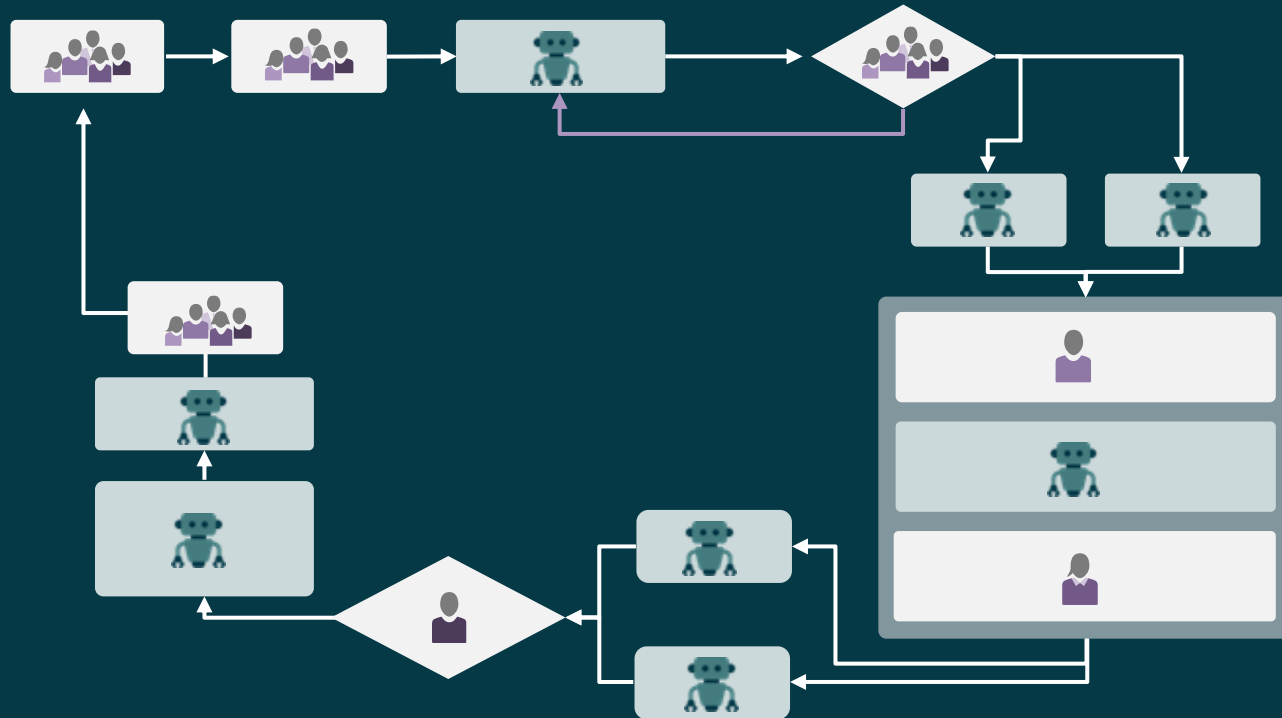
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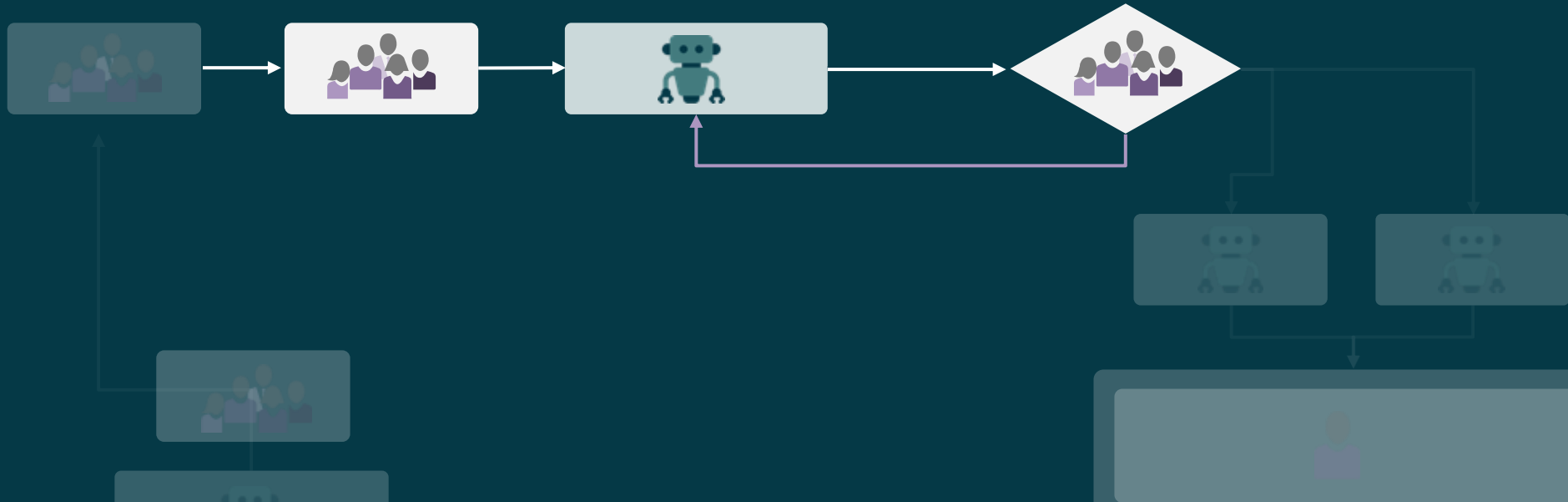
Development at Scale >>> Development & **Innovation at Scale**

Cross-Functional Teams >>> Cross-Functional, **AI-Augmented Teams**

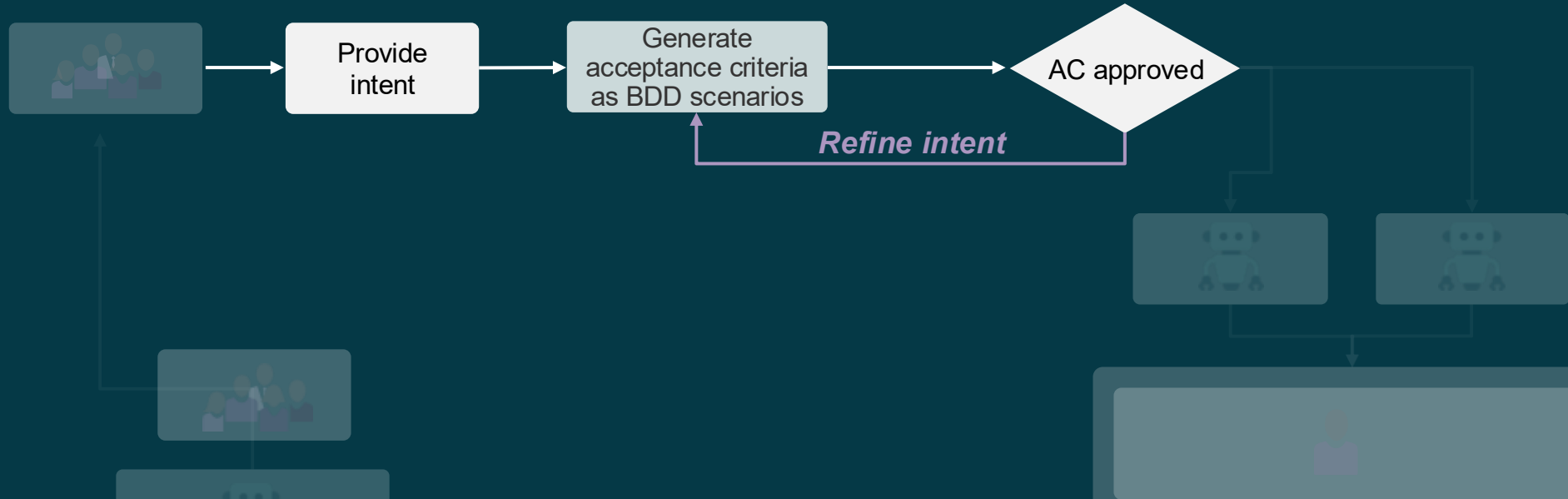
Integrate AI Teammates



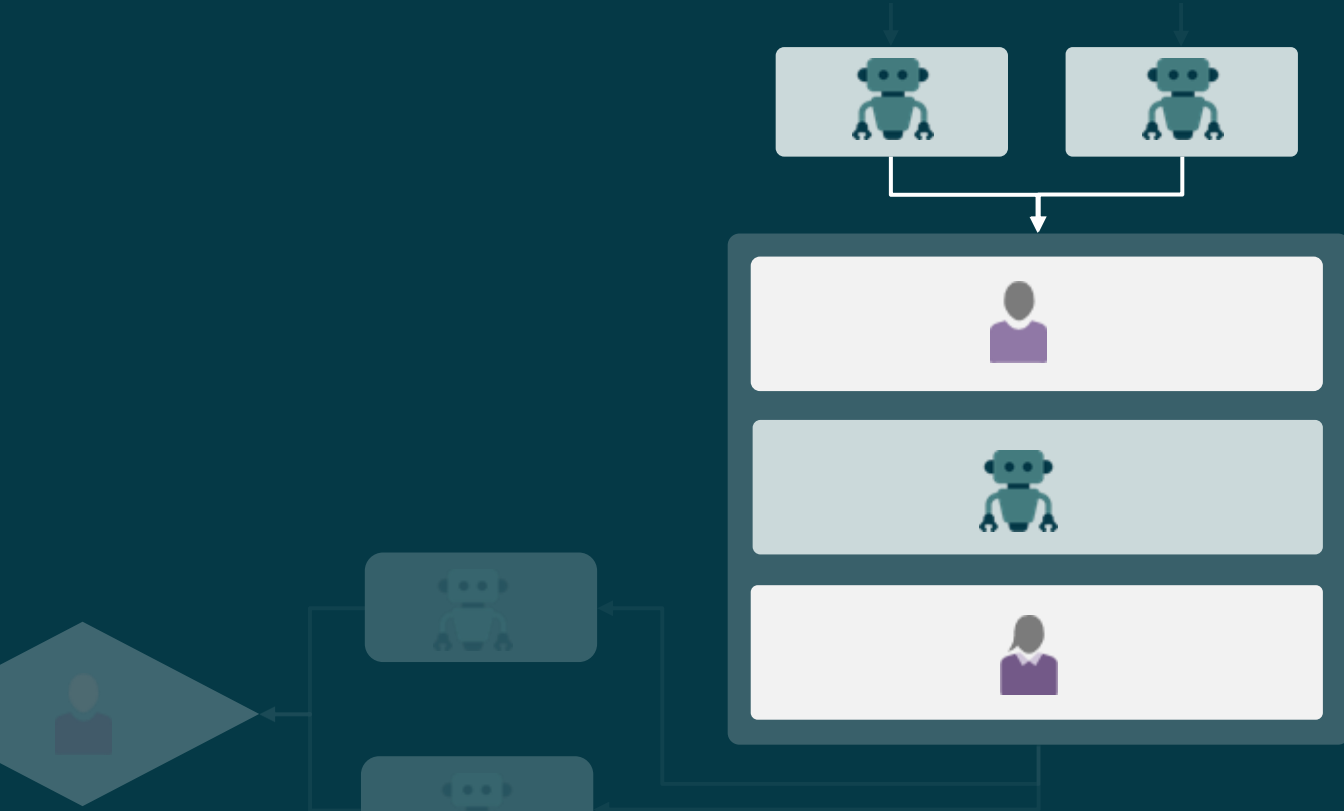
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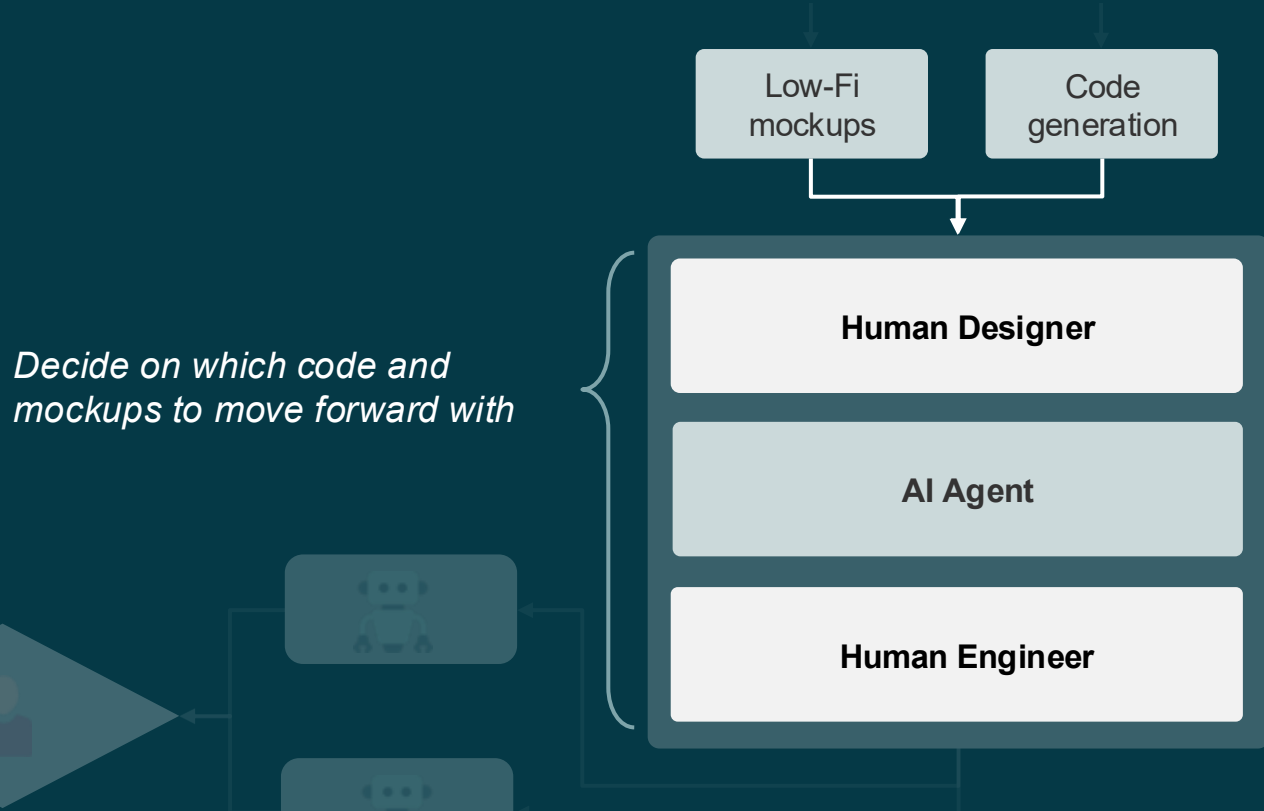
Integrate AI Teammates



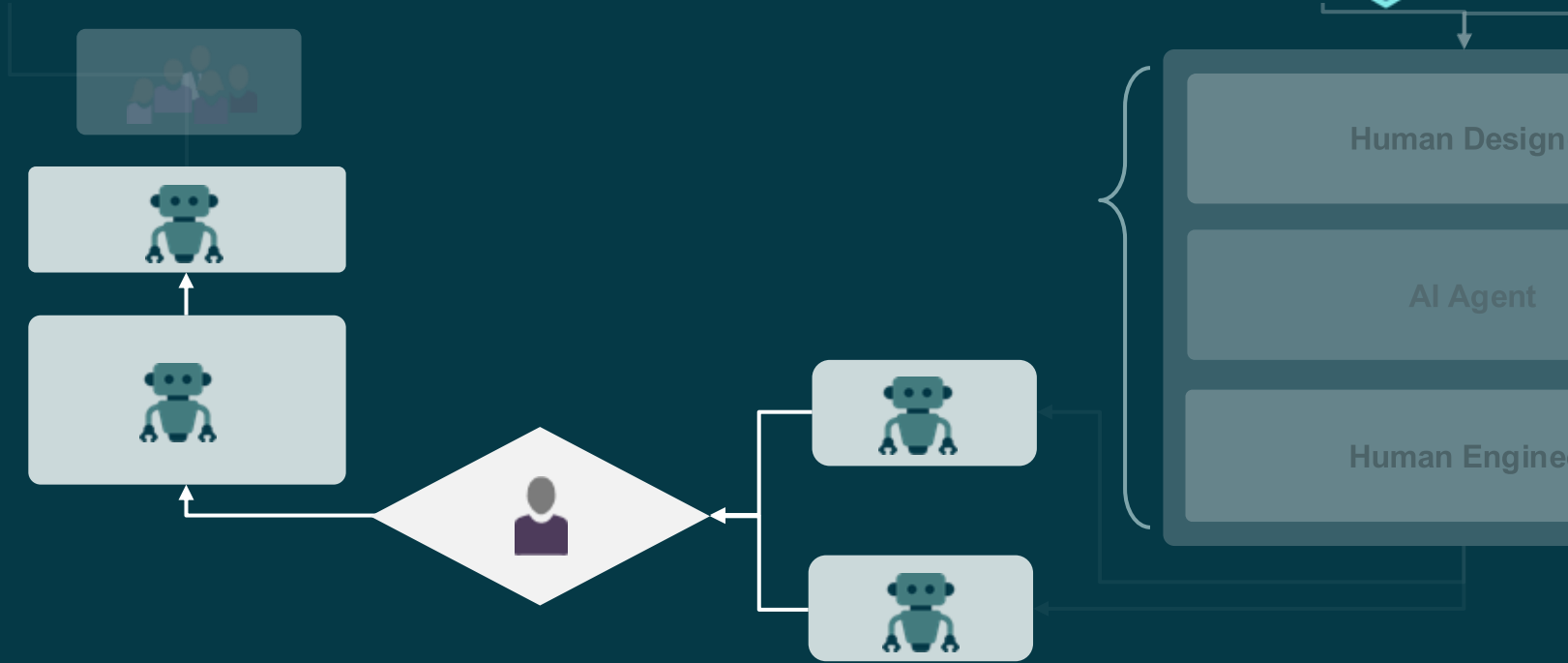
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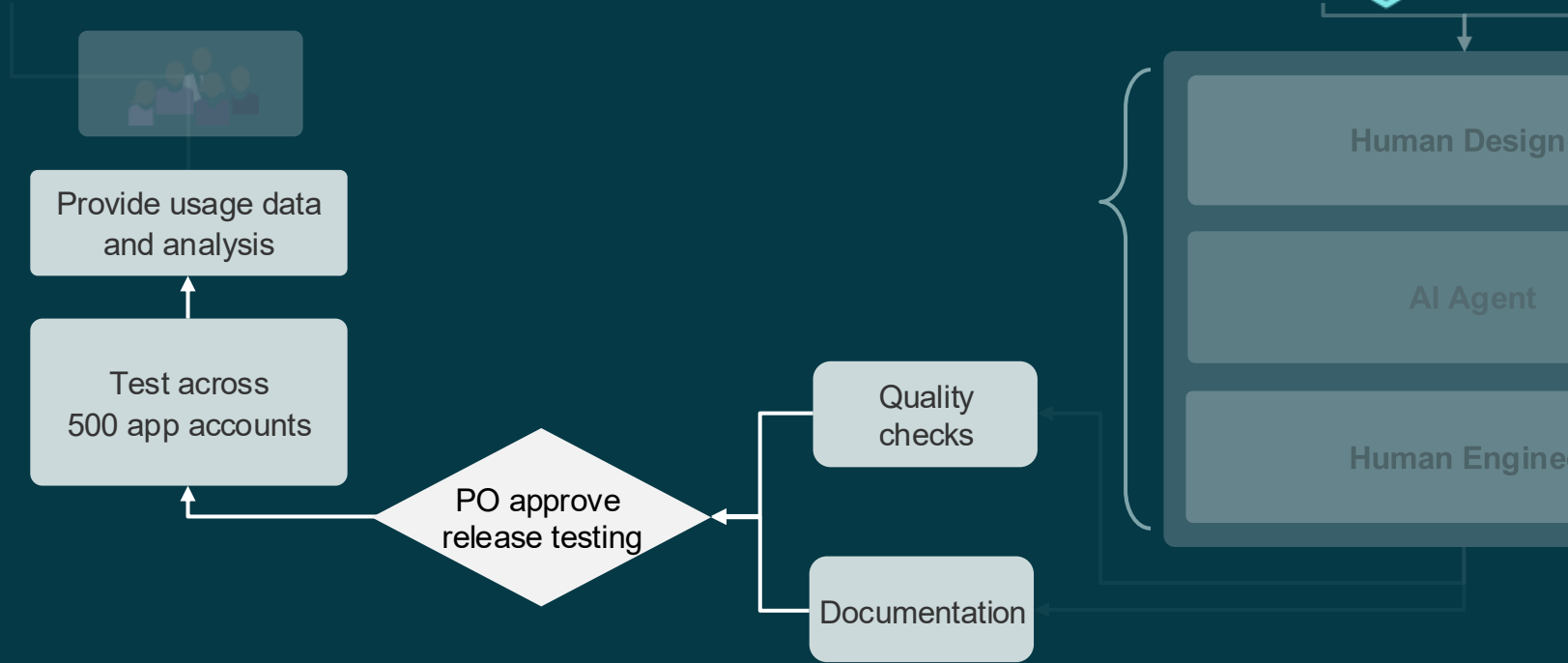
Integrate AI Teammates



Integrate AI Teammates



Integrate AI Teammates



AI-Empowered SAFe Certifications

Building AI into the DNA of your SAFe practice



More Courses Coming Soon!



AI-Empowered Agility

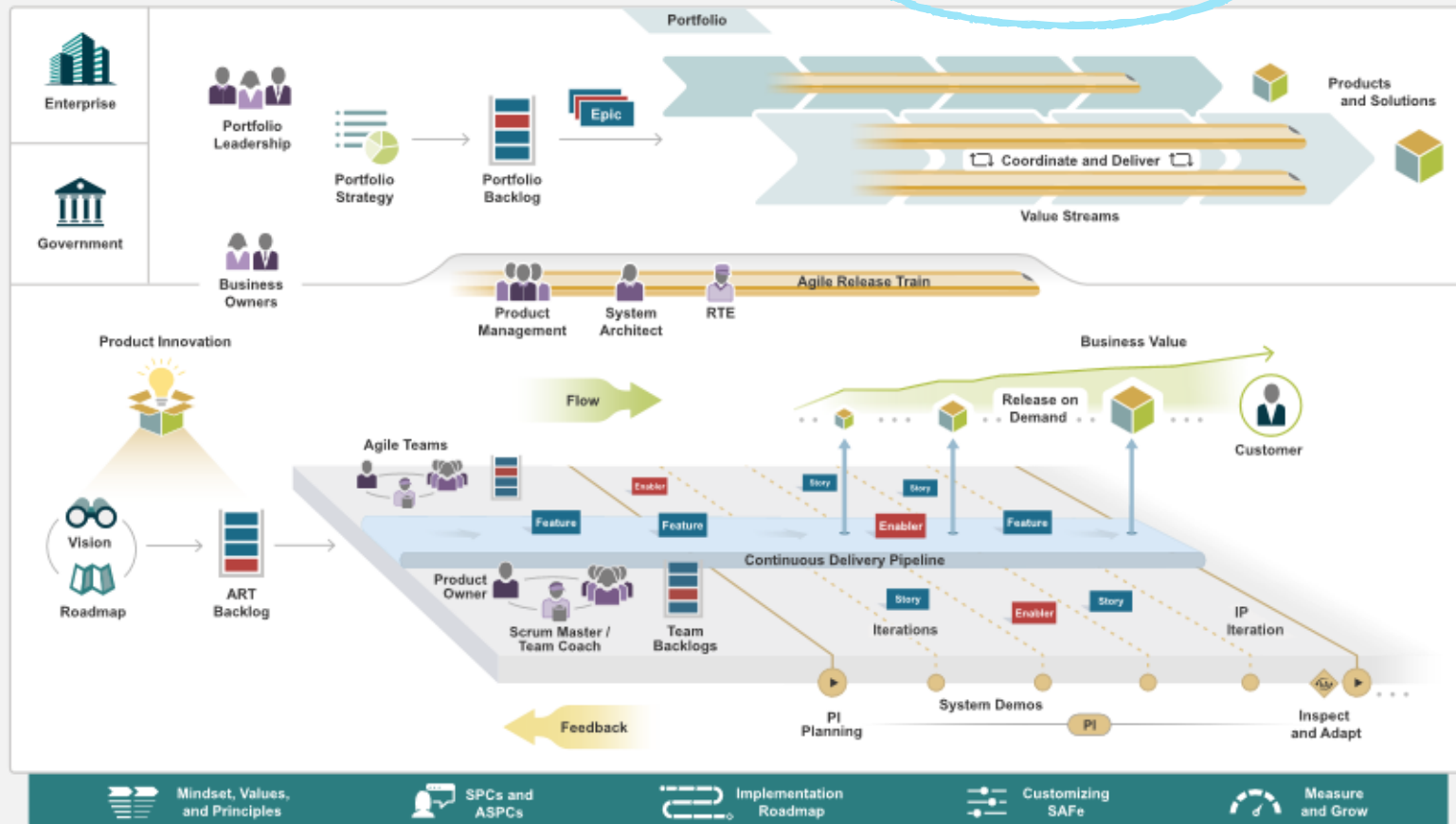
Focus on Outcomes >>> Focus on Outcomes & **Intent**

Iterative Learning Cycles >>> Iterative Learning & **Rapid Experimentation Cycles**

Development at Scale >>> Development & **Innovation at Scale**

Cross-Functional Teams >>> Cross-Functional, **AI-Augmented Teams**

Sustained and Fostered by a **Human-Centric AI Culture**



THANK YOU

Please rate this session!

